

BETHANY SOCIETY, *Shillong*

Key people: **Shirleen A. B. Sawkmie,** President; **Carmo Noronha,** Secretary; **Bertha G. Dkhar,** Executive Director

Year of inception: **1981**

AN EQUAL CHANCE Visually impaired students at the computer lab of the Jyoti Sroat School

Photographs by **NILOTPAL BARUAH**

HELPING HAND IN THE HILLS

Bethany Society's work with physically and mentally challenged children in Meghalaya has transformed many lives

By **APARMITA DAS**

Pynhoi Tang, 42, still remembers standing on the roadside every morning, crying, as other children walked past with schoolbags. Visually impaired and repeatedly pushed out of school, she was labelled 'difficult'. In the mid-1990s, a neighbour took her to Bethany Society in Shillong. Later, when Pynhoi's mother returned to their village, she stayed back. Today, Pynhoi works at the NEIGRIHMS hospital in Shillong, supports her family financially, and remains closely connected to Bethany.

Stories like hers have defined the Bethany Society's work since 1981. Founded by Sister Rosario Lopez, a Spanish nun working in the remote Garo Hills, the society began when she repeatedly encountered children who were